

THE MICHAEL THORNE SERIES - BOOK ONE

The Facade of Justice

A Psychological Crime Thriller

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READING SAMPLE

Publisher manuscript

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About this reading sample

This reading sample contains a continuous excerpt from the beginning of *The Facade of Justice*. It is based on the edition identified on the cover. The text below is drawn from the manuscript and is not the complete book.

Excerpt length: approximately 4,745 words.

PROLOGUE

THE EMPTY SPACE

Claire Liang noticed the empty space before she noticed the man watching her.

The photograph had been there less than ten minutes earlier, centered beneath the white track lights on the north wall of Meridian Gallery. Now only the brass hook remained, throwing a thin, crooked shadow across the paint.

Around her, Chicago's winter elite continued to drink champagne and speak too loudly about art they had no intention of buying.

Claire stood with an empty glass in one hand and stared at the gap.

It was not large. Twelve inches wide, perhaps fifteen high. In any other room it might have been overlooked, but Negative Space was an exhibition built around absence. Every object had been placed to make the viewer conscious of what was missing: a chair with one leg removed, a portrait whose face had been cut from the canvas, a family photograph in which one figure had been painted over in white.

Nothing in the room was accidental.

Especially not an empty hook.

"Claire?"

She turned.

A woman in a silver dress had been speaking to her. Claire recognized the face but not the name. One of the trustees, perhaps. Or the wife of someone who had donated enough money to expect recognition.

"I'm sorry," Claire said. "What were you saying?"

“The Varga piece.” The woman pointed toward a black canvas marked by a single vertical tear. “Is it meant to represent grief?”

“It can.”

The woman waited, apparently expecting more.

Claire offered the answer she had given three times that evening.

“Varga believed the viewer completes the work. Whatever you bring to the absence becomes part of it.”

The woman smiled as though Claire had confirmed something profound.

“How wonderful.”

She moved away.

Claire looked back at the wall.

The missing photograph had been the least dramatic piece in the room. It showed an old artist’s studio: paint-spattered floorboards, a wooden easel, a metal stool and the lower edge of a large unfinished canvas. No people. No signature. No title beyond the one Claire had assigned for the exhibition catalogue.

STUDIO, UNKNOWN ARTIST, CIRCA 1990

It had arrived six weeks earlier among the contents of an estate sale in Bridgeport. Most of the collection had been worthless—student sketches, damaged prints, amateur landscapes—but the photograph had bothered her from the moment she found it.

Not because of what it showed.

Because of what it seemed to avoid showing.

The camera had been angled downward, as if the person taking the picture had deliberately excluded the upper half of

the room. A dark stain marked the edge of the canvas. A man's polished shoe was visible in the lower-right corner, cropped at the ankle.

The auction house had called it a processing error.

Claire had not believed them.

Three days ago, a conservator had identified a name pencilled on the reverse of the mounting board.

J. THORNE

She had not yet told anyone.

Now the photograph was gone.

Claire set her glass on a passing waiter's tray and moved toward the wall.

A hundred and thirty guests filled the gallery. Their voices rose and folded into one another beneath the exposed steel beams. Outside the tall windows, snow moved sideways through the streetlights, turning the city into a blurred charcoal drawing.

She checked the floor first.

Nothing.

The mounting wire had not snapped. There were no fragments of glass or broken frame. Someone had lifted the photograph cleanly from the hook.

Claire looked toward the reception desk.

Maya, her assistant, was helping an elderly collector wrap a catalogue. Two security guards stood near the main entrance, both watching the crowd with the vague concentration of men whose real concern was the clock.

No one appeared alarmed.

Claire turned slowly, scanning the room.

That was when she saw him.

He stood beside the far window, partly obscured by a suspended sculpture made of black wire. A dark suit. White shirt. No tie. One hand rested near his waist; the other held nothing.

He was not looking at the art.

He was looking at her.

Claire met his gaze.

He did not smile or look away.

For one strange second she had the impression that they had already spoken, though she knew they had not. He was the kind of man she would have remembered: controlled, self-contained, almost unnaturally still amid the shifting crowd.

Then a pair of guests crossed between them.

When they passed, the man was gone.

Claire moved quickly toward the window.

The suspended sculpture turned gently in the heated air. Beyond it stood an empty section of floor and the emergency exit, its red alarm bar untouched.

She searched the adjoining room.

Nothing.

"Looking for someone?"

Claire flinched.

Maya stood behind her, holding a half-empty bottle of champagne.

"The photograph," Claire said. "The one from the north wall."

Maya looked past her. "What about it?"

“It’s missing.”

The assistant’s expression changed. She placed the bottle on a pedestal that was not designed to hold drinks.

“You’re sure?”

Claire pointed.

“Oh.”

“Yes. Oh.”

“Could Nathan have moved it?”

“Without telling me?”

Maya glanced toward the entrance. “I’ll check.”

“Don’t make an announcement. Just ask security to close the doors quietly.”

The words sounded excessive as soon as Claire said them. The photograph had little market value. The frame was worth more than the print.

But someone had removed it during a crowded private opening without being seen.

And the man by the window had been watching her notice.

Maya lowered her voice. “Do you think it was stolen?”

“I think it didn’t walk away.”

Claire crossed to the reception desk and opened the drawer beneath the computer. The gallery’s security monitors were in the office at the rear, but the desk stored the nightly inventory sheets.

She found the page for the north wall.

The photograph was listed as item seventeen.

No red mark indicating removal. No buyer’s sticker. No loan restriction.

“Claire.”

A male voice close behind her.

She turned too quickly and struck the drawer with her hip.

The man standing there was not the one from the window.

This one wore a camel coat over a tuxedo and had the flushed, pleased face of someone who had been drinking since lunch. Leonard Avery. Donor, developer, occasional patron and permanent obstacle.

“Extraordinary evening,” he said.

“Thank you.”

“I’ve been trying to get your attention.”

“I’m dealing with something.”

“So am I.” He leaned closer. “Your staff told me the Marovic installation isn’t available.”

“It belongs to the artist’s foundation.”

“Everything is available.”

“Not that.”

He studied her, amused. “You’re very serious tonight.”

“One of the works has been removed.”

“Sold?”

“Missing.”

His eyebrows rose. “Stolen?”

“We don’t know.”

Avery glanced toward the guests, visibly delighted to have encountered a scandal before anyone else.

“Should I be concerned about my coat?”

“Only if someone mistakes it for art.”

He laughed.

Claire did not.

Avery's smile thinned. "You know, I was trying to help."

"Then help by not repeating what I just told you."

He raised both hands and walked away.

Claire watched him until he was lost among the guests.

Her pulse had begun to beat too hard.

She told herself it was anger. The opening had taken four months to organize. Every label, light angle and wall measurement had been checked twice. She had spent the morning replacing one plinth because its surface was a shade warmer than the others.

Control mattered because control was the difference between a room and an experience.

The empty hook was not merely theft.

It was an intrusion into the composition.

Maya returned with one of the guards, a broad man named Louis whose uniform always looked a size too small.

"No one has left with a package," he said.

"The frame is twelve by fifteen inches. It could fit under a coat."

"We've been at the doors all night."

"Both of you?"

His hesitation answered.

"One of us at all times."

"Who was covering the service exit?"

"Alarmed."

"Who was watching it?"

“The camera.”

“Then show me.”

Louis looked toward the remaining guests. “Now?”

“Yes, now.”

Maya touched Claire’s arm. “I can handle the room.”

Claire nodded. “Start encouraging people toward the door. Politely. Don’t mention the photograph.”

She followed Louis through the staff corridor.

The gallery changed behind the public walls. White paint gave way to exposed brick. Music faded beneath the hum of ventilation. Packing crates stood against one side, labelled for exhibitions that had not yet opened.

At the end of the corridor, Louis unlocked the security office.

The room smelled of dust and warm electronics. Six monitors covered the wall, each divided into four camera feeds. The images were colourless and slightly delayed.

Claire saw the gallery from above.

Guests drifted through rooms they had already begun to leave. From this angle they looked less like patrons than pieces being moved around a board.

Louis sat at the console.

“What time did you last see the photograph?” he asked.

Claire checked her phone. “Around nine forty-five.”

“And when did you notice it missing?”

“Ten minutes later. Maybe less.”

He selected the north-wall camera and dragged backward through the recording.

People accelerated into jerking, silent movements.

“Slower.”

Louis reduced the speed.

The photograph appeared on the wall. Guests passed in front of it. A waiter stopped nearby. Two women posed for a picture.

Then the image froze.

The time stamp read 9:48:17.

A line of static crossed the monitor.

The feed resumed at 9:51:02.

The photograph was gone.

Louis leaned forward.

“What happened?”

“Signal interruption.”

“For nearly three minutes?”

“Could be the encoder.”

“Did any other camera lose signal?”

He checked.

The main gallery feed had continued normally. So had the entrance, reception desk and service corridor.

Only the camera facing the north wall had failed.

Claire felt something cold move through her that had nothing to do with the snow outside.

“Show me the entrance during those minutes.”

Louis switched views.

Guests moved in and out of frame. No one carried the photograph. No one appeared to be hiding anything beneath a coat.

“The service exit.”

The corridor remained empty.

"Back up farther," Claire said. "To nine thirty."

"Which camera?"

"All of them."

Louis gave her a look but did as asked.

They watched the gallery fill and shift.

At 9:34, Claire appeared on the north-wall feed speaking to a museum curator. She watched herself gesture toward the exhibition, smile, nod and move away.

At 9:36, the man in the dark suit entered the frame.

Claire leaned closer.

"There."

Louis stopped the recording.

The camera had captured the man from behind as he studied the old photograph. Medium height. Dark hair. Dark suit cut close at the shoulders.

"Can you enlarge it?"

Louis zoomed.

The image broke into pixels.

The man turned slightly. His face remained obscured by the reflection of a track light.

He stood in front of the photograph for nearly two minutes.

Then Claire entered the frame.

She approached him.

Claire stared at the screen.

"That didn't happen."

Louis looked at her. "That's you."

“I know who I am.”

On the monitor, the recorded Claire stopped beside the man. They appeared to speak. Her posture was attentive, her head tilted as if listening closely.

The man pointed toward the lower-right corner of the photograph.

The visible shoe.

Claire leaned nearer to inspect it.

Then she nodded.

“I never spoke to him.”

Louis looked from the monitor to her. “Maybe you forgot. You’ve been talking to people all evening.”

“I did not forget.”

The footage continued.

The man removed something from his pocket.

A small round object attached to a chain.

He held it between them.

Even without sound, Claire imagined she could hear the ticking.

On the screen, her recorded self looked down at it.

The image flickered.

For a fraction of a second, the man turned toward the camera.

His face dissolved into static.

When the picture returned, he was gone.

Claire remained beside the photograph, alone.

She stood there for another thirteen seconds, staring at the wall.

Then she walked away.

Louis rubbed his jaw. "That's strange."

Claire could hear her own breathing.

"Play it again."

He did.

She watched herself approach.

Watched the silent exchange.

Watched the flash of metal in the man's hand.

Nothing entered her memory.

No voice.

No face.

No conversation.

Only the certainty that she had first noticed him much later by the window.

"Can the footage be altered?" she asked.

"Anything can be altered."

"Here?"

"Not without access."

"Who has access?"

"Me. Nathan. The installation company."

"Anyone else?"

Louis hesitated.

"The remote maintenance contractor."

Claire looked again at the frozen image of the man holding the object.

"What is that?"

Louis enlarged it until the pixels blurred.

“Watch, maybe.”

“Not a wristwatch.”

“No.”

Claire already knew what it was.

A pocket watch.

She had seen one earlier that evening.

The memory came suddenly: a gloved hand resting beside the exhibition catalogue; a silver chain disappearing into a dark waistcoat. The man had asked whether the photograph came from the police evidence archive.

She had thought he was joking.

Or had she?

Claire pressed two fingers to her temple.

“Export the footage.”

“I’ll need an external drive.”

“There are drives in the top drawer.”

Louis opened it.

Empty.

“That’s where we keep them.”

“Use mine.”

Claire handed him the small drive attached to her key ring.

He inserted it into the console.

The screen went black.

Every monitor in the room died at once.

The ventilation fan stopped.

For one breathless moment the room was completely silent.

Then, from somewhere behind Claire, came a soft metallic click.

Louis swore.

Emergency lights glowed dimly along the floor.

“What happened?” Claire whispered.

“Power.”

“The rest of the building?”

Light still showed beneath the corridor door.

Louis rose. “Stay here.”

“No.”

He opened the door and stepped into the corridor.

Claire followed close behind.

The gallery’s main lights remained on. Voices drifted from the front. Maya was thanking the final guests.

Only the security office had lost power.

Louis checked the breaker panel.

“The circuit’s been shut off.”

“By whom?”

He pointed toward a switch.

It had been pulled down manually.

Claire looked along the corridor.

Packing crates. Closed doors. Bare bulbs.

No movement.

Then she noticed the office at the far end.

Her office.

The door stood open.

She was certain she had closed it.

“Did you go in there?” she asked.

Louis followed her gaze. “No.”

Claire moved toward it.

“Wait.”

She did not.

The office was small, with a steel desk, two visitor chairs and shelves crowded by catalogues. Her computer monitor cast a blue-white glow across the room.

Someone had awakened it.

On the screen was the live security feed from the north wall.

The empty hook remained in the centre of the image.

Claire stepped closer.

A figure appeared at the edge of the frame.

Dark suit.

White shirt.

He walked slowly across the gallery toward the camera.

Not toward the wall.

Toward whoever was watching.

Claire stopped breathing.

The man reached the centre of the image and lifted his face.

The resolution distorted him, but she saw enough.

Calm eyes.

A still mouth.

Nothing hurried or uncertain in the way he looked into the lens.

He raised one hand.

Between his fingers hung the missing photograph.

Then he turned it around.

The back of the frame faced the camera.

Words had been written across it in black ink.

Claire leaned toward the monitor.

YOU CROPPED THE WRONG MAN

Behind her, Louis said, "What the hell?"

The man on the screen lowered the photograph.

He looked past the camera, as though seeing someone enter the gallery.

His head turned.

Claire followed the direction of his gaze.

The live feed showed the gallery's north room.

Empty.

But from the main space beyond Claire's office came the sound of glass breaking.

Maya called her name.

Claire ran.

She found her assistant near the reception desk, staring at a champagne flute shattered on the floor.

"Sorry," Maya said. "It slipped."

Claire gripped the edge of the desk.

"Where is everyone?"

"Gone. Last couple just left."

"Lock the front door."

Maya studied her face. "What happened?"

“Lock it.”

Louis hurried toward the entrance.

The bolt slid into place.

Claire turned in a slow circle.

The gallery was transformed without its guests. The white rooms seemed larger, the installations more exposed. Music continued through the ceiling speakers, a slow cello composition selected for the evening.

She could see the north wall from reception.

The hook was no longer empty.

The photograph had been returned.

It hung exactly where it had before.

Claire took one step toward it.

Then another.

“No,” Louis said. “Stay here.”

She ignored him.

The frame appeared undamaged. The glass reflected the track lights in four perfect rectangles.

Claire stopped in front of it.

The photograph had changed.

The old studio remained: easel, stool, stained floorboards, unfinished canvas.

But the image was no longer cropped.

The upper portion of the scene had been restored.

A man lay against the canvas, his white shirt dark with blood. His head had fallen to one side. One hand rested beside a long, narrow blade.

Near the body stood a boy.

Twelve years old, perhaps.

Thin.

Motionless.

His face had been scratched from the photograph.

Behind the boy, another man crouched beside the dead body, reaching toward the blade with a handkerchief.

At the edge of the frame stood a third figure holding a camera.

The man's left hand was visible beneath it.

The little finger ended at the first joint.

Nolan Voss, though Claire did not yet know the name.

She read the handwritten label beneath the image.

The printed card she had prepared was gone.

In its place someone had written:

THE FIRST RESTORATION CHICAGO, 1991

Maya came up behind her.

"Is that the same picture?"

Claire did not answer.

She was staring at the boy.

His face had been destroyed, but something remained visible at his waist.

A silver chain.

It led to a round object in his bloodstained hand.

A pocket watch.

The cello music stopped.

The gallery fell silent.

Then the lights went out.
Maya screamed.
Louis shouted for everyone to stay where they were.
Claire heard the front door rattle.
Once.
Twice.
Then stop.
Emergency lighting failed to engage.
The darkness was absolute.
Claire reached for Maya but found only air.
“Maya?”
No answer.
“Louis?”
A dull impact sounded near reception.
Something heavy fell.
Claire backed toward the wall.
Her shoulder struck the frame. It shifted, scraping against the paint.
She held both hands in front of her, trying to orient herself.
The room smelled different.
Not champagne or perfume.
Metal.
Cold air.
And something faintly medicinal.
A small sound began close to her.
Tick.

Pause.

Tick.

Pause.

The pocket watch.

Claire pressed herself against the wall.

“Who are you?”

No answer.

“What do you want?”

The ticking moved closer.

She thought of the photograph. The dead man. The boy without a face. The figure holding the camera.

James Thorne.

She had searched the name after the conservator found it. A Chicago police officer. Decorated twice. Dead in 1991 in what newspapers described as a murder-suicide.

His wife had died that night.

Their twelve-year-old son survived.

Claire had not found the son’s name.

The ticking stopped.

A voice spoke from the darkness.

Quiet. Male. Controlled.

“You should have left the picture buried.”

Claire felt a sharp pressure at the side of her neck.

A sting.

She tried to move, but a hand caught her shoulder and held her upright.

“What did you—”

Her legs weakened.

The man guided her downward rather than letting her fall.

Even then, the gentleness terrified her more than violence would have.

He knew exactly how quickly the drug would work.

Claire tried to call Maya's name.

Her tongue no longer obeyed.

The darkness shifted. She sensed him kneeling in front of her.

A gloved hand lifted her wrist and placed something cold against her palm.

The frame.

He folded her fingers around its edge.

Claire fought to keep her eyes open.

Light returned in fragments as the track lamps flickered one after another along the ceiling.

The man stood over her.

She saw only the lower half of him clearly: dark trousers, polished black shoes, one knee marked by gallery dust.

A silver chain curved from his waist.

He opened the pocket watch.

The face was cracked beneath the repaired glass.

The hands pointed to 2:17.

Claire looked past him toward the north wall.

The photograph had been removed again.

Only the brass hook remained.

The empty space was the last thing she saw.

CHAPTER 1

THE BODY IN THE FRAME

Claire Liang was discovered at 6:12 the following morning by Maya Brooks, who had returned to Meridian Gallery because Claire had not answered six calls and had missed a conservation appointment for the first time in eleven years.

* * *

The front door was locked.

* * *

The alarm was armed.

* * *

Maya entered with the code Claire had given her for emergencies and found Louis unconscious behind the reception desk. He was breathing. A bruise had spread from his temple into the hairline, and a chemical smell clung to the collar of his uniform.

* * *

Claire lay beneath the empty hook on the north wall.

* * *

The man who killed her had arranged the room after the power returned.

* * *

Her body rested on a low conservation platform that had been moved from the workroom. Her back was straight. Her head turned toward the missing photograph. A white wooden frame lay across her lap, and both hands had been placed around its lower rail.

* * *

The lower-right corner was open.

* * *

Not broken.

* * *

Unfinished.

* * *

Across the floor, written in powdered charcoal:

* * *

RESTORED

* * *

Detective Elena Martinez reached the gallery first.

* * *

Michael Thorne arrived four minutes later.

* * *

Snow had become rain during the night. Water darkened the shoulders of his charcoal overcoat but had not disturbed the narrow line of his collar. He paused inside the entrance, removed his gloves and looked once toward the body.

* * *

Then toward the wall.

* * *

“The photograph is gone,” he said.

* * *

Elena turned.

* * *

“What photograph?”

* * *

Michael did not answer immediately.

* * *

The crime-scene photographer had not yet documented the north wall. No officer had mentioned a missing work over the radio. Maya stood near the rear corridor with a blanket around her shoulders, too shaken to speak.

* * *

Michael looked at the brass hook.

* * *

“There was a studio image above her.”

* * *

Elena studied him.

* * *

“How do you know?”

* * *

He looked toward the exhibition catalogue on the reception desk.

* * *

“Item seventeen.”

* * *

The catalogue remained closed.

* * *

Michael crossed the room without touching anything and stopped at the edge of the evidence boundary. Claire's fingers had been arranged with precision, but one thumb rested at a slightly different angle from the other. The frame corner opened toward her right knee.

* * *

He felt the need to close it.

* * *

The impulse came before grief, before professional assessment, before the question of who had killed her.

* * *

He kept both hands at his sides.

* * *

"Cause?" he asked.

* * *

The medical examiner looked up from the body.

* * *

"Unknown. No obvious penetrating trauma. Possible asphyxia or drug involvement. Injection mark near the neck."

* * *

Michael's gaze moved to the pale point beneath Claire's left ear.

* * *

A memory touched him without becoming visible.

* * *

Darkness.

* * *

A gloved hand.

* * *

A woman trying to speak.

* * *

He stepped back.

* * *

Elena noticed.

* * *

“You all right?”

* * *

“Yes.”

* * *

“You answered too quickly.”

* * *

Michael looked again at the frame.

* * *

“Who found her?”

* * *

“Maya. Security guard was unconscious. Power failure was limited to the office circuit. Camera facing this wall lost three minutes last night.”

* * *

“Only this camera?”

* * *

“Yes.”

* * *

“Remote access?”

* * *

“Voss Integrated maintains the gallery system.”

* * *

The name entered somewhere below conscious thought.

* * *

Michael’s right hand moved toward the chain beneath his waistcoat.

* * *

He stopped before touching the pocket watch.

* * *

“Who owns the company?” he asked.

* * *

“Working on it.”

* * *

A uniformed officer approached with Maya’s first statement.

* * *

“She says the missing picture was removed, returned with a different image, then disappeared again.”

* * *

“Different how?” Elena asked.

* * *

“Uncropped. Showed a dead man and a child.”

* * *

Michael’s breathing slowed.

* * *

“Name on the original mounting?”

* * *

The officer checked his notes.

* * *

“J. Thorne.”

* * *

Elena looked at Michael.

* * *

He did not look away.

* * *

“My father painted,” he said.

* * *

“That wasn’t the question.”

* * *

“No.”

* * *

“Was the photograph his?”

* * *

“I don’t know.”

* * *

Maya spoke from behind them.

* * *

“Claire knew.”

* * *

Her voice barely carried across the gallery.

* * *

Elena went to her. Michael remained near the evidence line.

* * *

Maya described the man in the dark suit. The pocket watch. The security footage showing Claire speaking to him even though she remembered no conversation. The restored photograph. The boy whose face had been scratched away.

* * *

Michael listened without interrupting.

* * *

When Maya repeated the words written on the frame—

* * *

YOU CROPPED THE WRONG MAN—

* * *

his left hand tightened.

* * *

Elena returned.

* * *

“You recognize the phrase?”

* * *

“No.”

* * *

“Your body disagrees.”

* * *

“That is not evidence.”

* * *

“No. But it is why you are not touching the scene.”

* * *

Michael accepted the restriction.

* * *

Crime Scene removed the exhibition catalogue from the desk. Item seventeen had been added three weeks after the other works. The typed line read:

* * *

STUDIO, UNKNOWN ARTIST, CIRCA 1990

* * *

Lender:

* * *

PRIVATE ESTATE

* * *

A handwritten correction appeared beneath the printed entry.

* * *

Not Claire's handwriting.

* * *

JAMES A. THORNE

* * *

A second line:

* * *

MARGARET VOSS ARCHIVE

* * *

Michael looked at the name.

* * *

Voss.

* * *

A camera shutter.

* * *

A hand missing part of one finger.

* * *

The images arrived without sequence.

* * *

He turned toward the body because the wall had begun to feel closer.

* * *

Claire's left hand carried a shallow cut along the palm. Charcoal had been pressed into the skin. Beneath her fingernails, the technician found tissue.

* * *

“She fought,” Elena said.

* * *

“Or the scene wants us to believe she did.”

* * *

Elena’s expression hardened.

* * *

“A woman is dead, Michael.”

* * *

“I know.”

* * *

“Then stop speaking as though the room is the victim.”

* * *

He looked at Claire.

* * *

For one second, her face became another face.

* * *

His mother’s.

* * *

Then Claire again.

* * *

“I’m sorry,” he said.

* * *

Elena did not know whether he spoke to her or the body.

* * *

The forensic photographer documented the white frame. A latent examiner found no usable print on the exposed rails. The interior edges would be processed after removal.

* * *

Michael watched the lower-right corner.

* * *

Unfinished.

* * *

His discomfort increased until he shifted his weight two inches to the left, aligning the open joint with the vertical edge of the display wall behind it.

* * *

Relief moved through him.

* * *

Small.

* * *

Immediate.

* * *

Elena saw.

* * *

She did not comment.

* * *

At 7:04, a crime-scene technician called from the security office.

* * *

The missing three minutes had returned.

* * *

Not on the gallery system.

* * *

On a remote backup server registered to Voss Integrated.

* * *

The recovered sequence showed Claire standing beneath the photograph.

* * *

A man approached from outside the camera's visible field.

* * *

Only his right hand entered the image.

* * *

Dark glove.

* * *

Silver chain.

* * *

Pocket watch.

* * *

Claire looked at him and became still.

* * *

The feed corrupted before his face appeared.

* * *

When it resumed, she was gone.

* * *

The photograph remained on the wall for eleven seconds.

* * *

Then someone lifted it from behind the partition.

* * *

Michael watched the sequence twice.

* * *

Elena watched him.

* * *

“Could that be your watch?”

* * *

“Many watches have chains.”

* * *

“Could it be yours?”

* * *

“Yes.”

* * *

“Where was yours last night?”

* * *

“At home.”

* * *

“Can anyone confirm?”

* * *

“No.”

* * *

“Did you come to Meridian?”

* * *

“I don’t remember doing so.”

* * *

Elena’s face changed.

* * *

Not suspicion yet.

* * *

Recognition of a familiar problem she had hoped belonged only to sleepless nights and missed meals.

* * *

“How much time?” she asked.

* * *

Michael checked the watch.

* * *

The hands showed 7:11.

* * *

He remembered leaving the precinct at 10:08 the previous night.

* * *

He remembered entering his apartment.

* * *

He remembered placing his keys in the ceramic dish beside the door.

* * *

After that, nothing until 4:36 in the morning, when he woke seated at his kitchen table with the pocket watch open in front of him.

* * *

“Six hours,” he said.

* * *

Elena’s eyes moved to the silver chain.

* * *

“Give me the watch.”

* * *

He did not move.

* * *

“Michael.”

* * *

He removed it carefully and placed it in her gloved palm.

* * *

The face was cracked beneath repaired glass.

* * *

The hands showed the correct time.

* * *

Elena turned it over.

* * *

Engraved on the back:

* * *

M.J.T.

* * *

A dark residue filled one letter.

* * *

Charcoal.

* * *

Michael stared at it.

* * *

He had cleaned the watch two days earlier.

* * *

Elena sealed it inside an evidence bag.

* * *

For the first time since entering Meridian, Michael looked afraid.

* * *

Not of the dead woman.

* * *

Of an object he had carried for twenty years.

* * *

Behind them, the technician lifted Claire's white frame.

* * *

A word had been written beneath it where the body concealed the floor.

* * *

Not charcoal.

* * *

Blood.

* * *

MICHAEL

Continue reading

You have reached the end of this reading sample from *The Facade of Justice*. The complete work continues beyond this excerpt.

The Michael Thorne Series - Book One